WHICH COMBINATION OF TACTICS SHOULD IOS EMPLOY?

As we have argued, IOs confronting populist backlash must employ a diverse portfolio of strategies, which we have categorized across two dimensions: the target of the strategy (leaders versus constituents) and the approach (appeasement versus sidelining). We suggest that IOs that fail to balance these tactics, instead relying primarily on one or two types, are particularly vulnerable to legitimacy crises and policy paralysis. Normative concerns arise when certain combinations of tactics dominate, leading to outcomes ranging from populist co-optation to total state disengagement.

To illustrate these dynamics, table 9.2 provides our preliminary expectations of populist responses, depending on whether appeasement or sidelining strategies dominate for both populist leaders and their constituents. As the table shows, when an IO simultaneously appeases both populist leaders and their constituencies, it risks co-optation, such that the IO realigns in support of the populist agenda. While the IO may continue to enjoy some participation and engagement, its independence and authority are likely to be eroded.

TABLE 9.2. Typology of combinations of IO responses to populism

	Appease leader	**Sideline leader**
Appease constituents	Co-optation	Muddle along
Sideline constituents	Participation/co-optation	Disengagement/ hostility

In such a scenario, the organization's behavior is increasingly driven by populist demands and rhetoric, internalizing populist critiques rather than constraining them. IOs may even reduce their commitments to multilateralism in favor of nationalist objectives. While this may prevent populist withdrawal, it undermines the IO's credibility among nonpopulist actors. Moreover, co-optation may be unstable; as the IO becomes more accommodating, populists may escalate their demands, further hollowing out the organization.

At the opposite extreme lies the strategy of dual sidelining, in which IOs deliberately distance themselves from both populist leaders and their